

LIFE AS ART (clockwise from far left) installations by CAMP; Jitish Kallat's 'Covering Letter'; a viewer taking a look at an artwork by Archana Hande



second visit. "Sometimes the spaces are more interesting than the artwork," she says, "The Kochi Biennale is unique because of the dialogue between the art and the people and spaces in the city."

Kang was disappointed by the delayed opening; she had made the long journey from the US especially for this, but, she says, "I enjoyed many of the collaterals; Jitish Kallat's 'Covering Letter' and Amar Kanwar's *Such a Morning* (2017), both video installations, were highlights, as were *Shadow Circus* (1998) by Ritu Sarin and Tenzing Sonam, and *Bhumi*, a community art project initiated during the lockdown with craftspeople in a village in north-western Bangladesh. At the students' biennale, the brickwork installation of A. Livingstan and Shivaganam was striking." The increased digital footprint in this edition, not favoured by some, was deliberate, says Bose, a natural consequence of, and reflection on, our post-pandemic way of life.

Bengaluru-based artist Archana Hande is here to document her site-specific installation 'My Kotigge', in which she delves into the past to "explore the living archives of the everyday". She tells me she was a signatory to the open letter written by the artists about the 'organisational challenges' that plagued the opening, but "we have to emerge stronger and move on, not dwell on what is behind us". Visual anthropologist and photographer Biju Ibrahim speaks eloquently about his current project that is rooted in his village Kondotty in Malappuram. An earlier one, curated by Riyas Komu, had showcased the nearly 40 different communities living in a five-kilometre radius in Mattanchery in Fort Kochi: co-existence as integral to our lives as breathing, not something to be labelled as 'other'.

For Puri, the experience was also compelling in that "this is one of those ways of triggering powerful conversations that are often political in nature without turning the city into a political site. We have only institutional mechanisms for conducting the work of democracy in our country, few social and cultural ones. This is invaluable for that very reason."

My favourite of this edition remains *Idam* (Space), a special and fascinating exhibition showcasing around 200 diverse works of art by 34 contemporary Malayali artists at the magnificent Durbar Hall in the city. And if we ever needed proof that such events revitalise, energise and inspire ordinary people, it can be had in the crowds made up mostly of young people, who visit all the venues, with total footfalls to date nearly 700,000, forging threads of unity in our increasingly fractured spaces. ■

Elizabeth Eapen

BEYOND FORT KOCHI



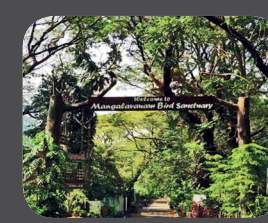
The Museum of Kerala History in Edapally, Kochi, run by the Madhavan Nair Foundation, is worth a visit. It includes a sound-and-light show detailing the history of the region through life-sized tableaux, a gallery of contemporary Indian art, a dolls museum, and a centre for visual arts.



The Hill Palace Museum in Tripunithura, Kochi, was once the administrative office and official residence of the Cochin Maharaja. The complex consists of 49 buildings in the traditional architectural style, an art gallery and expansive grounds.



Chendamangalam has some interesting Muziris sites, including one of the oldest-known synagogues built by the Malabar Jews, and Paliam House, which is now a museum. Ancient temples, churches, mosques and synagogues make Chendamangalam unique. There is also a handloom weaving centre.



The Mangalavanam Bird Sanctuary, a rather unkempt 2.74 hectares of green zone in the heart of the city, behind the Kerala High Court, attracts many migratory birds.